counter in terms of electoral chemistry as well," says a JD(U) leader. So, while the quota hike is targeted at re-establishing the connect with the OBCs, the financial assistance to the poor and homeless is expected to challenge the PM's assertion that the only caste the BJP is concerned about is of the poor.

Nitish has also followed his words with action. Some 122,000 teachers were handed recruitment letters on November 2, and fresh recruitment for an additional 120,000 teachers announced a week later. The message is clear. The Bihar government has filled existing vacancies, and created more to absorb the additional quota. The government is also planning to set up coaching centres for competitive examinations for the poor at the panchayat and district levels to make opportunities in jobs and education more equitable.

THE BJP COUNTER

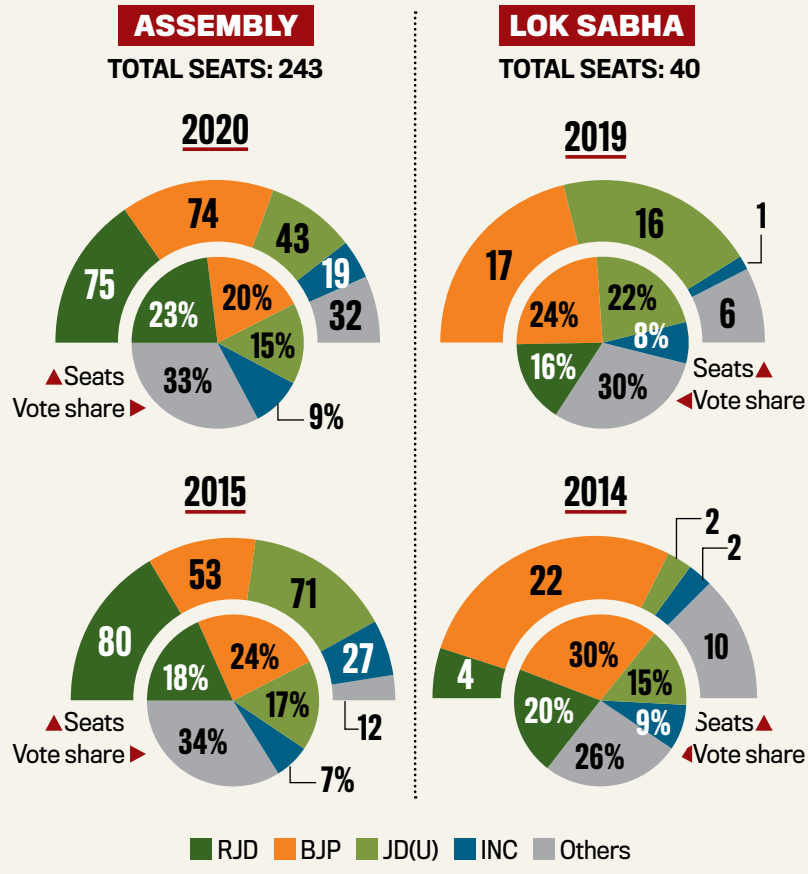
There is no doubting the Sudarshan Chakra Nitish has sent the BJP's way with caste count, quotas and doles. His timing, too, has been perfect. If the results of the caste survey stole the thunder of the women's reservation bill, Nitish's quota declaration came five days after the PM's announcement on November 4 that the free ration scheme will be extended for five years. "Our narrative is loud and clear. If the Centre offers free foodgrain to the poor, Bihar is empowering them with reservations and jobs," says a top JD(U) leader. "Let the poor themselves decide who is empowering them more, Nitish or the BJP government at the Centre."

For the moment, though, Nitish's move has left the BJP floundering for answers. When the caste survey was announced, some in the saffron camp even rushed to claim credit for having been part of the government when Nitish took the decision. The Bihar example has also triggered some rethinking in the BJP after Union minister of state Nityanand Rai had, in a written reply to a question in the Lok Sabha in 2021, categorically stated that the Centre had no intention of enumerating castes in the Census exercise. Union home minister Amit Shah found himself clarifying to presspersons on November 3 that his party was not opposed to the idea of a caste census, they just did not want to indulge in the "politics of votes" and that such decisions required "careful thought" and would be taken at "an appropriate time".

"Who'll believe them?" asks JD(U) secretary Nikhil Mandal. "The BJP claims to represent OBC interests but rejects the demand for a caste census despite knowing that the OBC will benefit the most from it. Nitish Kumar is the real OBC champion who has not just conducted a caste survey but also quickly passed on the empowerment benefits in the shape of reservation to those who deserve a helping hand." And so the battle for OBC votes continues. ■

THE ELECTORAL STAKES

How the parties have fared in the past two assembly and parliamentary polls



THE BJP HAS BEEN **STEADILY CHIPPING AWAY AT NITISH'S VOTE BASE,** WHILE PLAYING UP PM MODI'S BACKWARD CASTE CREDENTIALS AND ALSO ROPING IN OBC LEADERS FROM OTHER POLITICAL PARTIES